paid off, because we didn't want to take the easy option of delaying that pressure by asking Jimmy to give another demonstration of his darkest art.

It is all too easy to put back that appointment with destiny. I lost count of how many times the Gimp whispered: 'I hope we lose the toss and bowl.' The law of Sod being what it is, Straussy left a straight ball and was bowled with the second delivery of the following day, when the heat eventually took its toll.

Trotty's face was grey, almost waxy with tiredness, when he got out just before tea after we had put on 173 for the second wicket. During that interval I lay on the floor of the dressing room in a foetal position, completely drained. If there ever was someone to come to the fore in such a situation, it was Kevin Pietersen.

He was brilliant. He had been sitting for hours with his pads on, a showman in full make-up waiting in the wings for his cue. He hadn't been in the greatest touch on that tour, but when he emerged, he had an aura about him. He had clearly decided that this was his time. It is how I wish to remember him: expressive, powerful, creative, and so, so competitive.

We proved the attraction of opposites. By the close of the second day I had progressed to 136 not out, having broken the England record for runs scored and minutes at the crease without being dismissed, 371 in 1,022 minutes. When I was eventually out for 148, he had completed his first Test century in nearly twenty-one months.

My skill was in setting games up. His was in finishing off the opposition. He could single-handedly turn a game in four hours. He absolutely hammered them down, making a personal best 227. When he was on, he was extraordinary. There was a savage beauty to his batting. It was honestly a pleasure to be alongside him. Boy, could he run. His cricket brain was fantastic, calculating angles and recognizing space. He played shots beyond my scope.

My modus operandi when I was playing well was to suck up the pressure, wait for the bowler to stray into my area. Soak it up, take them down. When I batted with KP I concentrated on accumulation, rotating the strike with singles and hitting the occasional boundary. He would typically take between 60 and 70 per cent of the deliveries.

The opposition focus would be on him, which is just how he liked it. He was a big bloke, a massive presence. This isn't a show of false modesty, because I enjoyed applause as much as anyone, but I never really wanted to